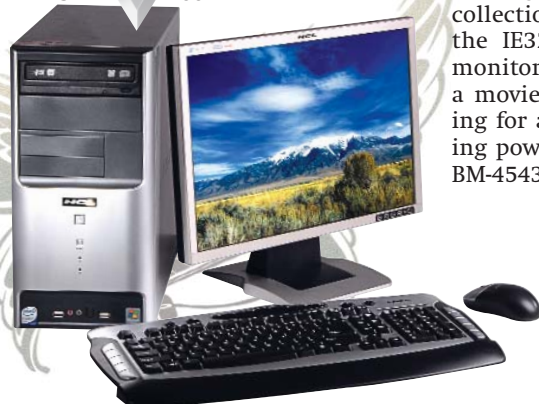


BEST BUY
digit
SEPTEMBER 2007



HCL EzeeBee Max XP Z999
Feature-rich, fancy-free

the other. Acer gets a nod ahead due to the superior bundle, though—11 discs consisting of games, movies, software, utilities, recipes, and an encyclopaedia. At Rs 25,000, if you're looking to start your DVD collection with a bang, get the IE3214. The widescreen monitor is attractive if you're a movie buff. If you're looking for a little more processing power, go with the Intex BM-45431.

A CUT ABOVE Desktops Between Rs 30,001 And Rs 40,000

This category is where the fun starts—all vendors

now have a good budget to work with. You can expect a better processor, perhaps more memory and a bigger hard drive. Discrete graphics is not a necessity unless you want to game a bit, but it's something to look for. (Integrated video solutions eat up valuable main memory to use as video memory.)

You should also look for at least a 19-inch LCD monitor—flat panels have become dirt cheap, and are easily available within this budget. If you're into multitasking a bit, then 2 GB of memory is the way to go.

Features *I want it!*

The LG XDZ caught our attention first. It deviates from the usual black colour scheme most vendors follow for a smoky grey hue. Opinions will differ drastically—some will love it, some will love to hate it: no lukewarm emotions here. A card reader has been cleverly integrated into what at first glance looks like a second CD bay flap. We also like the quality of the cabinet—it feels very sturdy, and the sheet used is quite thick.

Compaq's Presario SG3063IL looks just like its cheaper SG3053IL, except for the hardware under the hood. Zenith's 401G is passably usable as a mirror with its glossy front bezel. The rest of the cabinet is much the same: one sore point is the optical drives' eject mechanism—the front bezel that tilts outwards has the eject button built into it. When you eject the drive tray, the entire bezel (including the button) bends downwards—meaning you have to push the tray back into the drive.

Sahara's 20CK16 has the biggest cabinet of the lot—plenty of ventilation.

HP's Pavilion a6110in has an attractive transparent and backlit power button mounted atop the cabinet. In fact, all the HP and Compaq PCs had one common feature—when powering off, the button glows orange, and it'll glow green while powered. The card reader integrated into a floppy drive bay is functional.

How We Tested

PARAMETERS	WHAT WE LOOKED FOR
Features	
System Specifications	The hardware under the hood, correlated with price justifications. We gave points for larger monitors—widescreens got preference, as did bigger hard drives
Upgradeability	We looked at how much expansion is possible. After all, everyone needs to upgrade once in a while
Specifications And General Features	Number of USB ports provided, video connectivity, audio connectivity. We also checked for the software and add-on bundles and rated the PCs accordingly. Price points were considered
Ergonomics	How easy is it to access those USB ports? How good is the keyboard?
Performance	
PC Mark 2005	This synthetic benchmark tests the CPU, GPU, hard drive, and memory, and brings up scores. It is very sensitive to any change in components
SiSoft Sandra 2007	A little more detailed than PC Mark2005, this utility individually tests each performance-affecting hardware device, and lets us know how good each component is
3D Mark 2005	Tests the pixel and vertex shader capabilities of 3D acceleration hardware. Good for testing consumer graphics solutions. Its newer brother, 3D Mark 2006, is used to check enthusiast hardware
DisplayMate	Tests the capabilities of a monitor—since we were looking at multimedia capabilities like colour rendition and pixel response, we ran only the relevant tests
HD Movie Viewing	We played back a 1080p clip. Observations included stuttering, dropped frames, colour and crispness, and the suitability of the monitor for HD content
Video Encoding	Perhaps the most suitable real-world benchmark for testing a CPU's capabilities
File Transfer Test	Stresses out the hard drive, and is a good benchmark for storage. We used a 4 GB test file for sequential tests, and a mixture of different file types of varying sizes for random tests
Game Test: <i>Doom 3</i>	The OpenGL benchmark of choice—still one of the best geometry and shader engines in the business—scales very well with changes in CPU, memory, and GPU frequency or parts
Game Test: <i>FarCry</i>	The DX equivalent of <i>Doom 3</i> . This game features intensive shader operations and some great outdoor scenes with gorgeous detailing. Great for stressing out video solutions
Price	Cheap doesn't necessarily mean better—bang for your buck is what we're looking at
Operating System	Windows XP Professional with SP 2